

Barking burrower

The prairie dog is a type of squirrel that lives in networks of tunnels under the prairies. Its name comes from the barking noise it makes when it is alarmed. Before people started to farm the region, prairie dog colonies covered vast areas with millions of inhabitants.



Black-tailed prairie dog
(*Cynomys ludovicianus*)
Body length: up to 15 in (38 cm)
Tail: up to 3.5 in (9 cm)

White head

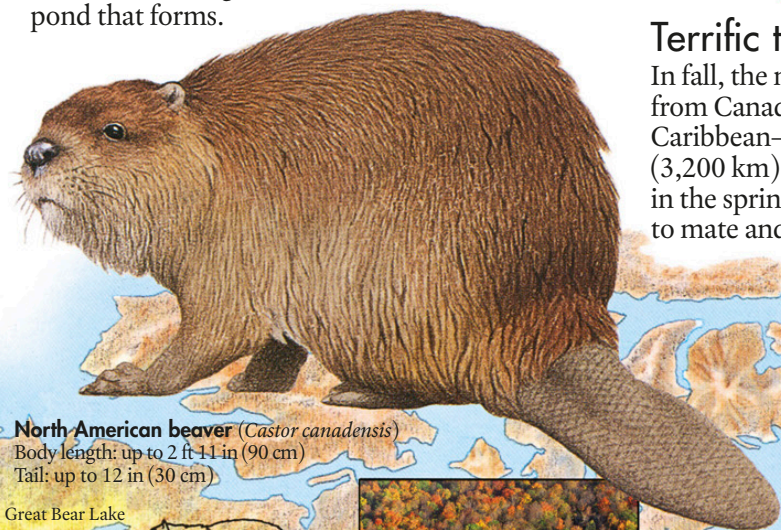
The bald eagle gets its name from its white head—an old meaning of the word “bald” is “white.” Bald eagles have spectacular courtship displays, in which the male and the female bird lock talons in flight and somersault through the air. Pairs build a huge nest of sticks, weeds, and soil and add to it each year.



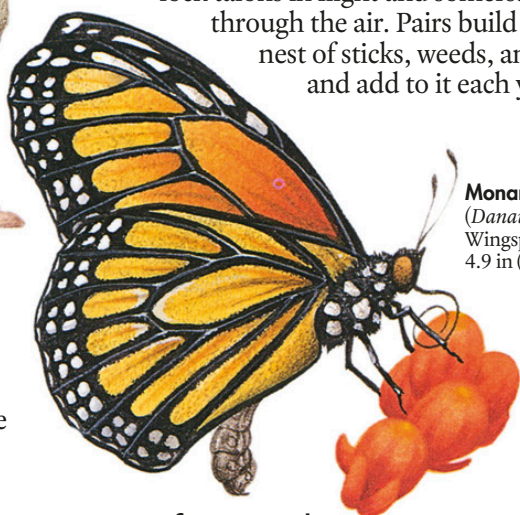
Bald eagle
(*Haliaeetus leucocephalus*)
Length: up to 3 ft 2 in (96 cm)
Wingspan: up to 8 ft (2.4 m)

Dam builder

The beaver has powerful jaws and strong front teeth, which it uses to gnaw through tree trunks. The beaver then builds a dam across a river, and a lodge of sticks and mud in the pond that forms.



North American beaver (*Castor canadensis*)
Body length: up to 2 ft 11 in (90 cm)
Tail: up to 12 in (30 cm)



Monarch butterfly
(*Danaus plexippus*)
Wingspan: up to 4.9 in (12.5 cm)

Terrific traveler

In fall, the monarch butterfly migrates from Canada to California, Mexico, or the Caribbean—flying more than 2,000 miles (3,200 km). It travels north again in the spring, but stops on the way to mate and then die.



Wolverine (*Gulo gulo*)
Height at shoulder: up to 17 in (43 cm)
Body length: up to 3 ft 5 in (105 cm)

Crushing bite

Known to kill animals as large as a caribou, the fierce wolverine is strong for its size, with a powerful, crushing bite. Its widespread toes help it bound across snow chasing its prey. A wolverine can travel over 40 miles (65 km) without resting.

Blue jay
(*Cyanocitta cristata*)
Length: 11.8 in (30 cm)



Tree planter

The blue jay often buries acorns and other tree seeds to eat later. Some survive to grow into new trees, helping the forest spread. In spring and fall, large flocks of blue jays migrate south to warmer climates.

Virginia opossum
(*Didelphis virginiana*)
Body length: up to 19.6 in (50 cm)
Tail: up to 18.5 in (47 cm)

Baby pouch

The opossum is North America's only pouched mammal. The young climb into the mother's pouch after birth and stay there for several months, feeding on her milk. To escape an enemy, opossums can “play dead,” and may stay in a trancelike state for hours.



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